MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

5/21/25 LW

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Un~~approved minutes
April 16, 2025

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Dale Majewski, District 3 Jacob Gross, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis, District 8 George Gilmore and District 9 Rick Fancon

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

None

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps, Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger, Deputy Clerk Isha Walter, members of the public and zoom participants

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the agenda, **motion carried**

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the Board of Commissioners Minutes of March 19, 2025, **motion carried**.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

A member of the public expressed his gratitude for the new speaker and microphone system. He expressed his concern regarding the lack of attendance for one of the Commissioners that sits on the Airport Committee. Also, he stated that in the previous meeting he requested a press release in regard to the total costs of all Clare County lawsuits since the information was being released regarding the former prosecutor's lawsuit. Chairman Gilmore responded that the prosecutor lawsuit was the first lawsuit that was taken out of the General fund, the other lawsuits were paid for by insurance money. Additionally, the same member of the public mentioned that he spoke to Prosecuting Attorney Andrew Santini in regard to his staffing and Prosecuting Attorney Santini clarified that he has three attorneys working in the office and the previous Prosecuting Attorney had a total of four.

The previous Airport Manager asked the Board of Commissioners to please support the Airport. He pleaded with the Commissioners to set up joint funding with the City of Harrison and Hayes Township so the Airport may have a stable source of income.

A member of the public questioned what the public benefit is for having an airport is for the community.

A citizen concerned about the airport asked the Board of Commissioners to consider accepting the Airport Grant of $254,000.00. He mentioned that the Federal Aviation Administration has already designated the funding for airports so if the Commissioners do not accept the grant it will just go to another airport and community.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT - continued

A member of the public who owns a hangar at the airport expressed his desire to have training classes at the airport for the youth of the community. It will be a great benefit for children of all ages to have the opportunity to learn to build and work on airplanes.

A city resident and private pilot encouraged the Board to accept the $254,000.00. He believes the airport is a benefit to the community and commented that additional businesses would come to Harrison if the airport were developed.

A Clare County resident, who is an aspiring pilot, stated that Clare County is a tourist area and the airport is necessary stating that a repair facility will attract pilots, a new building for the restaurant and a pilots' lounge, which are all possibilities for the airport. He urged the Commissioners not to close the airport.

A member of the public and United States Armed Forces Veteran highlighted how the airport will bring tourism and money. He asked the Commissioners not to make their decision about the $254,000.00 airport grant personal but to do what is good for the county.

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

1. Medical Examiner Monthly Report – No discussion

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps reported that there are no legislative updates and a few federally funded programs are on hold. The fiscal year 2026 budget template has been released to all the department heads for completion. The final audit was received on March 31, 2025 and once all the audit reports are completed, she will post them on the transparency page on the county website. She is working on streamlining the process regarding inmate health insurance with Blue Cross Blue Shield and confirmed that County Building emergency system tests (including tornado and fire drills) were recently conducted with successful results. Administrator Phelps reported that she is reviewing and updating several outdated policies, and she sent out several letters of support for organizations applying for grants over the past month. She closed by confirming that the County is a little under budget but expects some large invoices to be submitted in the coming weeks.

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS

1. Region VII Area Agency on Aging
   Chief Operating Officer and interim Executive Director Monica Freier gave a presentation on the various services and programs Region VII Area Agency offers the senior citizens of Clare County. She explained that Region VII Area Agency serves 10 counties in the state under the Older Americans Act. The agency distributes funds that come in through federal and state grants. Monica Freier pointed out that in 2024 Clare County paid $2,474 in dues yet received $418,000 in return. The MDHHS and ACLS Administration for Community Living Support are working with all the Region Area Agencies to make sure all available funds are being distributed in a timely manner.

   Monica Freier also explained that they are currently lobbying for the MI Choice Waver Program. The program provides in-home services for nursing facility level of care citizens keeping them where they want to be while still receiving the services needed. Last year 161 residents of Clare County benefitted from the MI Choice Waver Program. She encouraged the Commissioners to send senior citizens to Region VII Area Agency. Finally, she emphasized that they have a strong contingency plan in the rare occasion that funding ceased.

JUSTICE

1. Sheriff's Department Patrol Vehicles
   a. It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the early payoff of the 2023 patrol car lease utilizing approximately $30,000 from contingency, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Majewski, Gilmore, Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Hoefling, Kleinhardt, Housler, Haskell and Gross
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

   b. It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Gross to approve the new patrol unit lease starting October 2025 in the amount of $99,897.40, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Majewski, Kleinhardt, Housler, Hoefling, Haskell, Gross, Gilmore, Fancon and Ambrozaitis
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

1. Veterans Services
   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to accept the Fiscal Year 2026 County Veteran Service Fund Grant in the amount of $55,516.00, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Fancon, Gross, Hoefling, Kleinhardt, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Haskell, Housler and Majewski
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

1. Airport Grants
   a. It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to accept the Fiscal year 2025 State Local Program Funding Award of $250,000.00 for upgrade airfield lighting runway 18/36 at the Clare County Airport with no match required,

      It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to table the motion to accept the FY 2025 State Local Program Funding Award of $250,000.00 for upgrade airfield lighting runway 18/36 at the Clare County Airport with no match required until the next meeting, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (6) being Commissioners Fancon, Housler, Majewski, Kleinhardt, Gilmore and Haskell
      Nays: (3) being Commissioners Gross, Hoefling and Ambrozaitis
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT - Continued

b. It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to accept the Fiscal Year 2025 State Local Program Funding Award of $4,806.00 for seal pavement surface/pavement joints at the Clare County Airport with no required match,

It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Housler to table the motion to accept the Fiscal Year 2025 State Local Program Funding Award of $4,806.00 for seal pavement surface/pavement joints at the Clare County Airport with no required match until the next meeting,
roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (5) being Commissioners Housler, Majewski, Gilmore, Fancon and Kleinhardt
Nays: (4) being Commissioners Gross, Ambrozaitis, Hoefling and Haskell
Absent: (0)
Motion carried

2. Contract Equalization/Local Unit of Government
It was moved by Commissioner Haskell, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the contract for services between Clare County Equalization and the Local Unit of Government, **motion carried.**

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
It was moved by Commissioner Gross, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of March 17, 2025 in the amount of $56,901.44 and the meeting minutes of March 31, 2025 in the amount of $55,577.20, roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Gross, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Kleinhardt and Majewski
Nays: (0)
Absent: (0)
Motion carried

2. Monthly Expenditures
It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the expenditures for the month of March 2025 in the amount of $3,941,516.33 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,019,663.56, roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Gilmore, Haskell, Majewski, Kleinhardt, Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gross, Housler and Hoefling
Nays: (0)
Absent: (0)
Motion carried

3. Budget Adjustments
None

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

4. Policy Approval
   a. It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the updated Paid Sick Leave Policy, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Majewski, Haskell, Kleinhardt, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Hoefling, Housler, Fancon and Gross
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

   b. It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the updated Travel Policy, discussion followed

      It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to amend the updated Travel Policy to show that airfare is required to be approved by the County Administrator, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Majewski, Kleinhardt, Housler, Hoefling, Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Gross and Haskell
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

      It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the updated Travel Policy as amended, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Gross, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Kleinhardt and Majewski
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

   c. It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the updated Travel Policy Procedures, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Gilmore, Gross, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Fancon and Kleinhardt
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

   d. It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the updated Credit Card Policy, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Housler, Gilmore, Haskell, Kleinhardt, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Gross, Fancon and Hoefling
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

4. Policy Approval - continued
   e. It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the repeal of the Covid Preparedness Policy, roll call vote revealed:

      Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Gilmore, Haskell, Housler, Majewski, Kleinhardt, Hoefling, Gross, Fancon and Ambrozaitis
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (0)
      Motion carried

5. Airport Appropriation
   It was moved by Commissioner Haskell, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to appropriate $4,000.00 from the General Fund to the Airport Fund to cover the crack seal invoice, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Kleinhardt, Hoefling, Fancon, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Haskell, Gross, Gilmore and Housler
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

6. Personnel
   It was moved by Commissioner Gross, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to allow the replacement of a Circuit Court Clerk, Friend of the Court Case Worker, Corrections Officer and a 911 Dispatcher, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Gilmore, Housler, Kleinhardt, Majewski, Gross, Haskell and Hoefling
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

7. Tribute to Gale Bensinger
   It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to amend the agenda to remove the tribute to Gale Bensinger to a future date, **motion carried**

CLERK/REGISTER OF DEEDS REPORT

Clerk and Register of Deeds Lori Mott gave an update regarding the upcoming May election and confirmed the filing deadline for the August election is May 13, 2025. She also reported that the Veterans Coffee hour was a success and there were several veterans that signed up for the Property Fraud Alert.

TREASURER'S REPORT

Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger provided all the statutory reports to the Commissioners. She also included the final numbers for Fiscal Year 2024 because the audit is now complete, which showed Clare County ended with an addition of $862,791.00 to the Fund balance. Treasurer Beemer-Fritzinger noted that 2024 included $800,000 of ARPA funds. Settlement checks will be going out next week to the local townships and cities and her staff worked hard through the third tax deadline, which included 1,024 certificates of forfeiture for the 2023 tax year that were sent over to the Register of Deeds office for recording.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman George Gilmore had nothing to report.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Vice Chairman Rick Fancon gave kudos to Administrator Phelps for a stable budget and had no report.

COMMISSIONER'S REPORT

Commissioner Majewski had no report.

Commissioner Gross had no report.

Commissioner Haskell encouraged everyone to vote May 6, 2025 for the Career and Technical Education (CTE) millage renewal and had no report.

Commissioner Kleinhardt reported that Sheridan and Arthur Townships have been discussing being approached about windmills.

Commissioner Housler reported that the Transit Committee recently reported that all the buses are receiving tablets, which allows for the drivers to make more efficient trips and they have ordered a couple electric buses.

Commissioner Ambrozaitis commented that the Airport Committee is attempting to institute an Aviation Mechanics Program at the Career & Technical Education (CTE). Additionally, he announced that the Spring Fly-in is scheduled for May 17, 2025 from 8 a.m. until 11 a.m. and the next Airport Committee meeting is May 20, 2025 at 4p.m.

Commissioner Hoefling has attended his meetings and gave a report on each of the townships and committees he represents.

STATE OF THE COUNTY BUDGET

State of the County Budget was discussed during Administrator Phelps report.

PUBLIC COMMENT

A member of the public shared his idea on funding the airport by resuming the partnership with Hayes Township and the City of Harrison similar to how it was done in 2019.

Dewayne Rogers, Clare County Road Commission Manager, gave an update on ongoing and upcoming road projects. He also let the Board of Commissioners know that The Road Commission would like to have a more in-depth conversation regarding the airport.

A concerned citizen if the Commissioners would allow the Prosecutor's office to hire two new attorneys. Administrator Phelps explained that the Prosecuting Attorney has been actively interviewing.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

None

NEW BUSINESS

None

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to adjourn the meeting at 10:57 a.m., **motion carried**.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

George Gilmore, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners